

Financial counsellors are free, supportive advocates who are trained to help people from all walks of life in financial difficulty. Their services are confidential, and there are a couple of ways to locate a counsellor:

- Financial Counselling Australia, which represents financial counsellors: financialcounsellingaustralia.org.au. The website has a map to find a counsellor in your area.
- The National Debt Helpline: 1800 007 007. Partly funded by the Federal Government's Department of Social Services and the Victorian and New South Wales governments, the helpline provides confidential, over-the-phone assistance.

The helpline recommends prioritising debts and negotiating payment terms on your debts. Their website provides fact sheets to get you started, and the counsellors can walk you through these over the phone, without judgement. They are au fait with the steps you can take with a loan provider to meet your obligations, such as requesting to speak to the 'financial hardship' team. If you are feeling embarrassed or overwhelmed, and don't know how to handle the situation with your creditor or a debt collector, these counsellors will give you a roadmap to working it out.

Beyondblue can also put you in touch with lots of services. If you are feeling depressed and anxious about your financial situation, they can give you some referrals on 1300 22 4636, or at beyondblue.org.au

Top tips

Senior financial planner Paul Nicol says it's common that first home buyers, embarking on the earliest steps to saving for a property, will have some debt. Nicol, a senior partner of GFM Wealth Advisory, says that to wipe the slate as clean as possible, consider trying these methods:

Get on down

Go ahead – ask for a lower rate, Nicol says.

'Not many people consider that, but it is certainly a distinct possibility. Many people don't ask, whether it is a credit card, or whatever it might be. They [creditors] are often open to payment plans and the like.' Requesting a